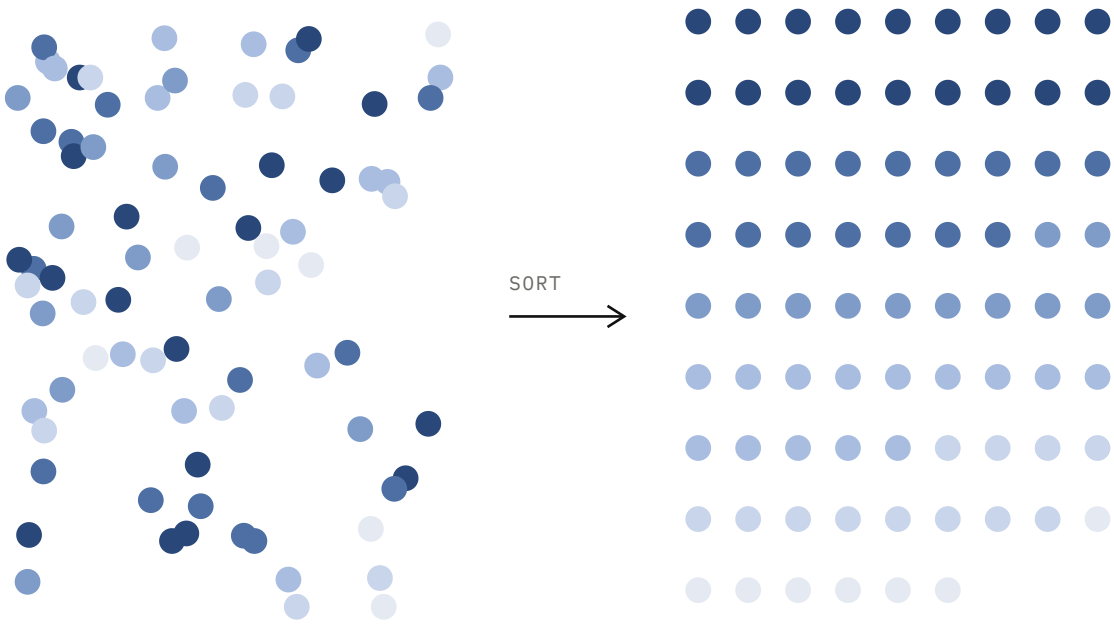
Kaizen Practice.

The Team Manager's Lean Playbook

How the work runs and keeps improving, for anyone who leads a team. Lean and continuous improvement, applied to everyday work.



TODAY KAIZEN PRACTICE

Sanjay Chandra
Global CoE Community
www.ssanjaychandra.com · github.com/ssanjaychandra123 · linkedin.com/in/ssanjaychandra

78 PATTERNS
24 SITUATIONS
6 TEMPLATES

Contents

Eight parts, one step at a time

Section 1 teaches one technique per problem, part by part. Section 2 combines them for real situations. Section 3 is the toolkit to copy.

CONTENTS

BEFORE YOU START The book on one page 03 Lean on one page 04

01 5S, Standards and Shared Information p. 05

1.01 5S 05
1.02 Handle once 06
1.03 Standard work 06
1.04 Living standard 06
1.05 One source 07
1.06 Answer once 07
1.07 Run checklist 07

02 Ownership, Handover and Cover p. 08

2.01 One owner 09
2.02 Decision levels 09
2.03 Intake rule 09
2.04 Swimlane map 10
2.05 Backup cover 10
2.06 Three passes 10
2.07 Hoshitori, skills grid 11
2.08 Request check 11
2.09 Shared vault 11
2.10 Pre-arrival 12
2.11 Task rotation 12
2.12 Leaver handover 13
2.13 Leave calendar 13

03 Updates, Meetings and Decisions p. 14

3.01 Hōkoku, report early 15
3.02 Ketsuron kara, conclusion first 15
3.03 Sōdan, ask in time 15
3.04 Gijiroku, meeting record 16
3.05 Nemawashi, talk first 16
3.06 Chōrei, short stand-up 16
3.07 Check before you promise 17
3.08 Response times 17
3.09 No agenda, no meeting 17
3.10 Action check 18
3.11 Meeting reset 18
3.12 Approval wait 18

04 Workload and Flow p. 19

4.01 Demand, capacity 20
4.02 WIP limit 20
4.03 Teiji, log-off time 20
4.04 Heijunka, level the load 21
4.05 Yutori, reserve capacity 21
4.06 Oldest job first 21
4.07 Small batches 22
4.08 Tōban, duty rota 22
4.09 One priority order 22
4.10 Key dates 23
4.11 Cut-off time 23

05 When Things Go Wrong p. 24

5.01 Jidoka, andon: stop and signal 25
5.02 Saihatsu bōshi, prevent a repeat 25
5.03 Shohō, first report 25
5.04 Person in charge 26
5.05 Kunren, the drill 26
5.06 Go-live check 26
5.07 Silent failure 27
5.08 Workaround list 27

06 Quality at the Source p. 28

6.01 Right first time 29
6.02 Done card 29
6.03 Jikōtei kanketsu, own your step 29
6.04 Hatsumono, first-piece check 30
6.05 Poka-yoke, mistake-proofing 30
6.06 Failure demand 30
6.07 Supplier quality 31
6.08 Named sign-offs 31

07 Running the Team p. 32

7.01 Mieruka, team board 32
7.02 Tiered huddles 33
7.03 Leader work 33
7.04 Hoshin kanri, goals into work 33
7.05 Gemba walk 34
7.06 Coaching kata 34
7.07 One-to-ones 34

08 Improving and Sustaining p. 35

8.01 Kaizen card 36
8.02 Baseline 36
8.03 Pareto tally 36
8.04 Small trial 37
8.05 Kamishibai, daily spot check 37
8.06 Yokoten, share sideways 37
8.07 Hansei, look back 38
8.08 Value stream 38
8.09 Kaizen hour 38
8.10 Problem first 39
8.11 Changed and told 39
8.12 Stop doing 39

S Situations p. 40

S.01 Taking over and changing how work is done 41
S.07 When work piles up 42
S.13 When things go wrong 43
S.19 Working with other teams 44

T Toolkit p. 46

T.01 Templates, six to copy 47
What to run, and how often 50
Japanese terms 51

Before you start

The book on one page

Read this page, then pick one thing to try on Monday.

START HERE

THE IDEA

Pick one standard. Make it visible. Use it every day. Improve it in small steps. That is kaizen. It needs time set aside, and a manager who backs people when a fix upsets someone.

THE ONE RULE

Bad news first, and fast. Nobody is punished for bringing it.

START MONDAY

01 Send the four-line update at 16:30

02 Put three measures on the team board

03 Book a 10-minute Friday reset

READ A PATTERN

01 **Label** code, name, and the matching FT and HL cards

02 **Problem** the heading: what you see, in one line

03 **Solution** what to do, in order

04 **Why it works** the human behaviour behind it

05 **Diagram** the idea in one picture

WHERE THINGS ARE

Contents, part by part 02

Section 1: the eight parts 05

THE PEOPLE IN THE EXAMPLES

Priya Reporting lead, owns the monthly report and the board figures

Ana Customer service lead and the best teacher, asks for access

Tom IT support lead, owns the shared tools and forms

Sam Long-serving, does the second check, knows the old systems

Lee Operations coordinator, sorts requests, runs practice runs

You The manager. All names are fictional

FIVE WORDS TO KNOW

FT, HL Framework Thinking and Hidden Logic, Books 1 and 3. "See FT 2.06" points to card 2.06 there

5S Sort, order, shine, standardise, sustain

無駄 Muda: waste

報連相 Hō-ren-sō: report, inform, consult

改善 Kaizen: small steps

自働化 Jidoka: stop on an abnormality, fix the cause

IF YOU ALREADY KNOW

RACI Simplified to owner, checker, decider. Part 2

Business continuity Backup cover for critical tasks. 2.05

Lessons learned Saihatsu bōshi, fix the cause. Part 5

Retrospective PDCA (plan, do, check, act) on a kaizen card. 8.01

Before you start

Lean on one page

Kaizen is the improvement half of Lean. The other half is flow: how a piece of work moves from the request to the person who needs it. This book covers both.

ORIENTATION

FIVE IDEAS



The five ideas follow James Womack and Daniel Jones, *Lean Thinking* (1996), who call the last one perfection.

WHERE EACH LIVES

LEAN IDEA	IN YOUR TEAM	WHERE IN THIS BOOK
Value	What the receiver needs, agreed before the work starts. Anything they would not pay for is waste.	6.02 Done card 6.01 Right first time
Value stream	Every step a request passes through on its way to the customer, and the waits between the steps.	8.08 Value stream 2.04 Swimlane map
Flow	Work moves without stopping: few items open at once, an even load, clear hand-offs.	4.02 WIP limit 4.04 Heijunka 4.01 Demand, capacity
Pull	New work starts when there is room for it.	2.03 Intake rule 4.02 WIP limit
Continuous improvement	Small changes, each one measured, held and spread: plan, do, check, act.	8.01 Kaizen card 8.02 to 8.06 7.06 Coaching kata

THE EIGHT WASTES AT WORK

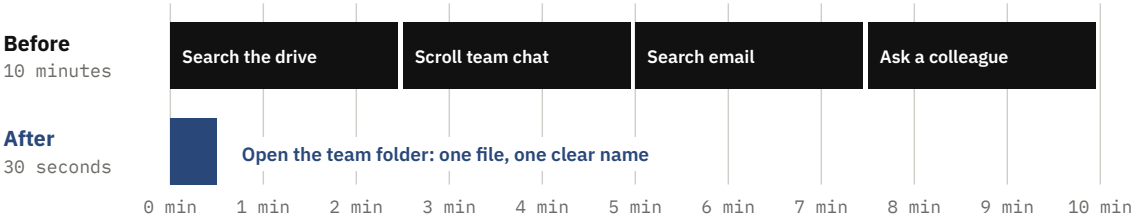
WASTE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE HERE	ROUTINES THAT FIX IT
Defects	Work sent back, errors found late	6.01 Right first time, 6.04 Hatsumono, 6.05 Poka-yoke, 5.01 Jidoka
Overproduction	Reports nobody reads, everyone copied in	8.12 Stop doing
Waiting	Approvals, queues, people blocked on an answer	3.12 Approval wait, 8.08 Value stream, 2.04 Swimlane map
Unused talent	Ideas and skills left unused	8.01 Kaizen card, 7.06 Coaching kata, 2.11 Task rotation
Transport	Retyping between systems, hand-offs that lose context	6.05 Poka-yoke, 2.04 Swimlane map, 2.06 Three passes
Inventory	Piles of half-done work, old jobs left open	4.02 WIP limit, 4.06 Oldest job first
Motion	Searching for files and answers	1.01 5S, 1.05 One source, 1.06 Answer once
Extra processing	Polishing nobody needs, too many sign-offs	6.02 Done card, 6.08 Named sign-offs
Muri, mura	Too much on one person. Quiet weeks, then a crunch	4.01 Demand, capacity, 4.04 Heijunka, 4.08 Tōban

5S, Standards and Shared Information

One place for every file, one way for every job.

5S AND THE HOW-TO GUIDE

THE TEST: ANYONE FINDS THE LATEST VERSION OF A TEAM DOCUMENT IN 30 SECONDS



WHAT EACH STEP CHANGES

- **1S** Sort
- **2S** Set in order
- **3S** Shine
- **4S** Standardise
- **5S** Sustain

IN THIS PART

1.01	5S	05	1.05	One source	07
1.02	Handle once	06	1.06	Answer once	07
1.03	Standard work	06	1.07	Run checklist	07
1.04	Living standard	06			

1.01 5S

Files sit anywhere, and finding one takes ten minutes.

SOLUTION

01 Give each kind of file one home.
02 Start every file name with the date.
03 Tidy the folders every Friday for ten minutes.

WHY IT WORKS

Tidiness fades without a regular reset.

TODAY: FOUR PLACES, NO RESET



AFTER: ONE HOME, ONE NAME, A FRIDAY RESET



1.02 HANDLE ONCE

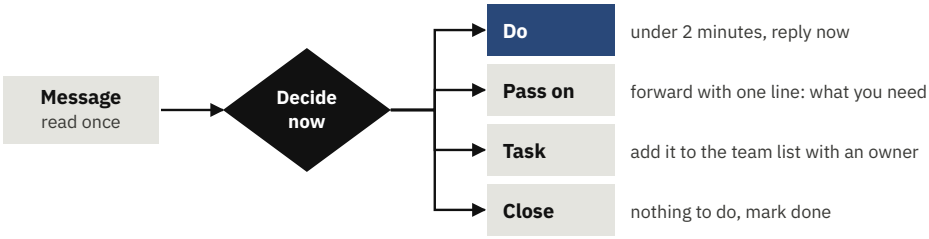
In a full inbox, the message that mattered gets missed.

SOLUTION

01 Open each message once.
02 Do it, pass it on, list it or close it.
03 Check messages at set times.

WHY IT WORKS

A message left undecided keeps costing attention.



EVERY MESSAGE LEAVES YOUR LIST IN ONE OF FOUR WAYS

1.03 STANDARD WORK

Everyone does the same task a different way.

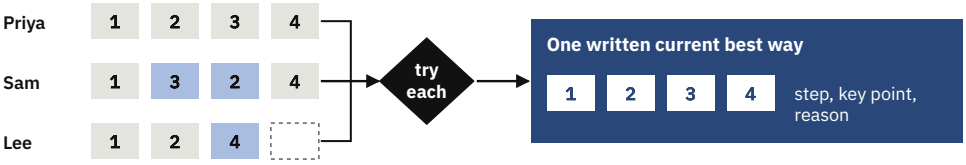
SOLUTION

01 Watch two people do the same task.
02 Agree the best way, step by step.
03 Write it on one page together.

WHY IT WORKS

People follow a way that is easier, or that you check.

THREE HEADS, THREE VERSIONS



EACH LEARNED IT FROM SOMEONE ELSE

1.04 LIVING STANDARD

The how-to guide exists, and nobody follows it.

SOLUTION

01 Give each guide an owner from the team.
02 Keep it to one dated page.
03 Update it when someone finds a better way.

WHY IT WORKS

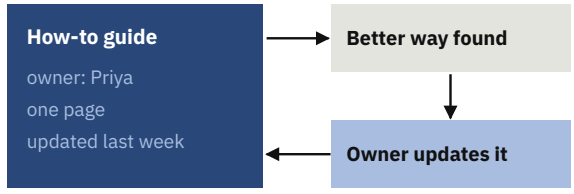
People ignore a guide that no longer matches the work.

TODAY: THE OLD GUIDE

How-to guide
written 2019
12 pages
author has left

nobody opens it

LIVING STANDARD



the team uses it, and changes it

1.05 ONE SOURCE

The same document sits in several places, all different.

SOLUTION

01 Keep one master copy in one place.
02 Share links, never attachments.
03 Archive the other copies with a pointer.

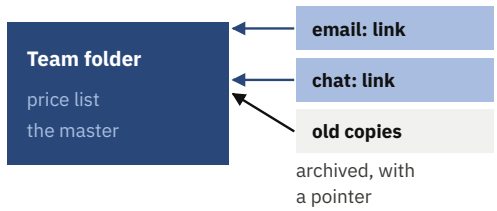
WHY IT WORKS

People trust whichever copy they found first.

TODAY: FIVE COPIES, ALL DIFFERENT

email **v3**	desktop **final**	chat **final 2**
drive **v5 edits**	USB stick **old**	

ONE MASTER, LINKS ONLY



1.06 ANSWER ONCE

The same question gets asked ten times a week.

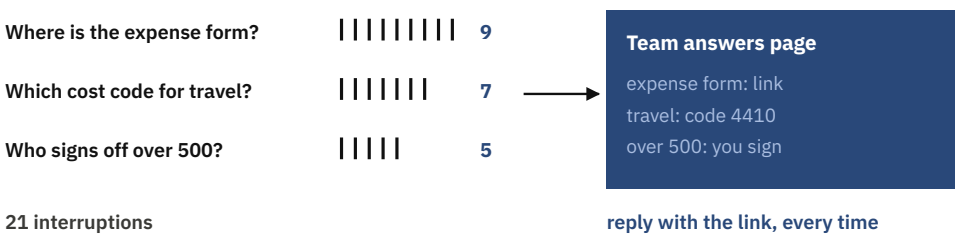
SOLUTION

01 Tally the questions that keep coming back.
02 Write one short answer for each.
03 Reply with the link every time.

WHY IT WORKS

People ask whoever is nearest when no answer is written down.

QUESTIONS THIS WEEK



1.07 RUN CHECKLIST

A step in the monthly task got missed again.

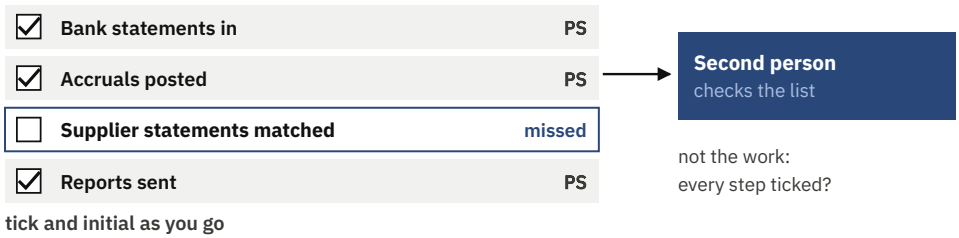
SOLUTION

01 Turn the task into a tick list.
02 Tick and initial each step as you go.
03 A second person checks the list.

WHY IT WORKS

Memory fails on tasks done once a month.

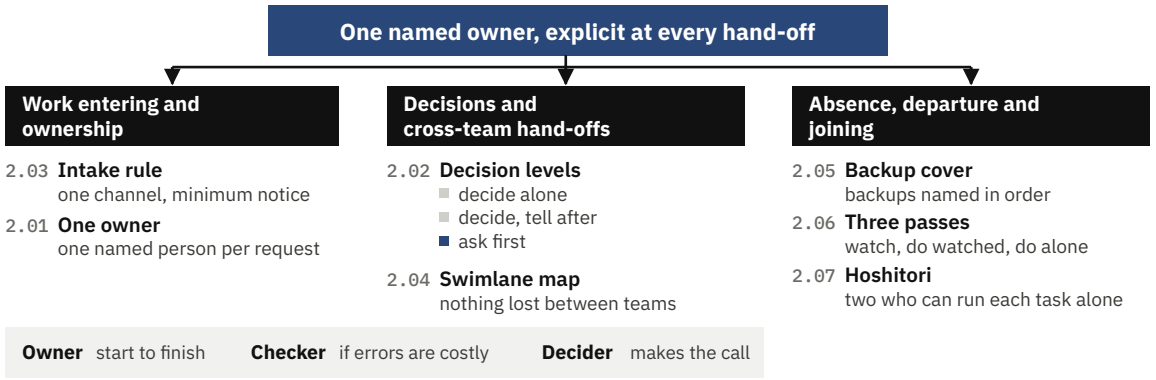
MONTH-END CLOSE: THE RUN CHECKLIST



Ownership, Handover and Cover

Every piece of work has one named owner.

RESPONSIBILITY AT EVERY HAND-OFF



IN THIS PART

2.01	One owner	09
2.02	Decision levels	09
2.03	Intake rule	09
2.04	Swimlane map	10
2.05	Backup cover	10
2.06	Three passes	10
2.07	Hoshitori, skills grid	11
2.08	Request check	11
2.09	Shared vault	11
2.10	Pre-arrival	12
2.11	Task rotation	12
2.12	Leaver handover	13
2.13	Leave calendar	13

2.01 ONE OWNER

See FT 5.02 · HL 7.06

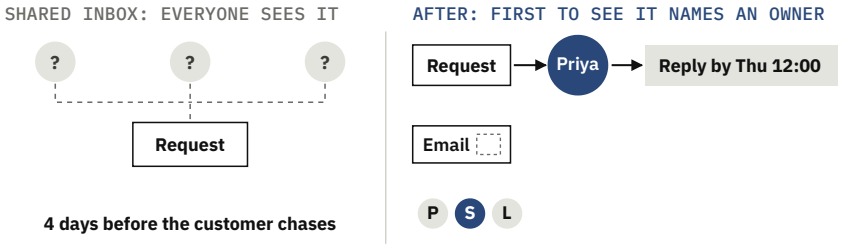
In a shared inbox, everyone thinks someone else has it.

SOLUTION

01 The person on duty names an owner each morning.
02 The owner's name goes on the request.
03 No name means a red flag.

WHY IT WORKS

When everyone is responsible, nobody acts.



2.02 DECISION LEVELS

See FT 5.02 · HL 7.07

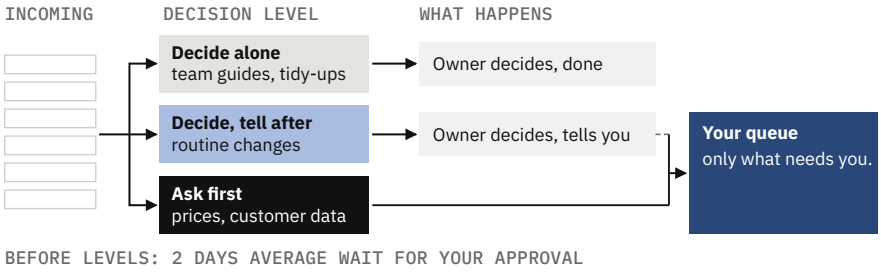
Every small decision waits for you.

SOLUTION

01 Agree three decision levels with the team.
02 Write them down with real examples.
03 Then back their calls, even ones you would not make.

WHY IT WORKS

People ask when they are unsure of their limits.



2.03 INTAKE RULE

See HL 6.08

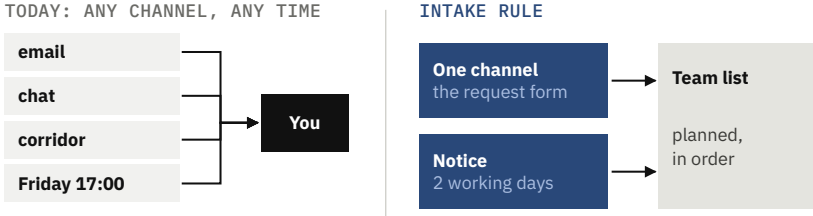
Work gets dropped on you late, through any channel.

SOLUTION

01 Agree one channel for all requests.
02 Agree a minimum notice, say two days.
03 Point every other channel to that one.

WHY IT WORKS

Peers will use the channel. Seniors won't, so log their requests yourself.



2.04 SWIMLANE MAP

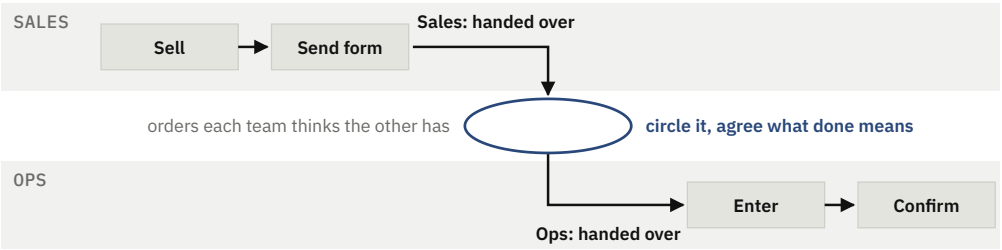
Work goes missing between two teams.

SOLUTION

01 Draw the process with one lane per team.
02 Circle every hand-off.
03 Agree what done means at each one.

WHY IT WORKS

Work gets lost where nobody owns the hand-off.



ASK EACH SIDE SEPARATELY: DIFFERENT ANSWERS MARK THE GAP

2.05 BACKUP COVER

See HL 5.02

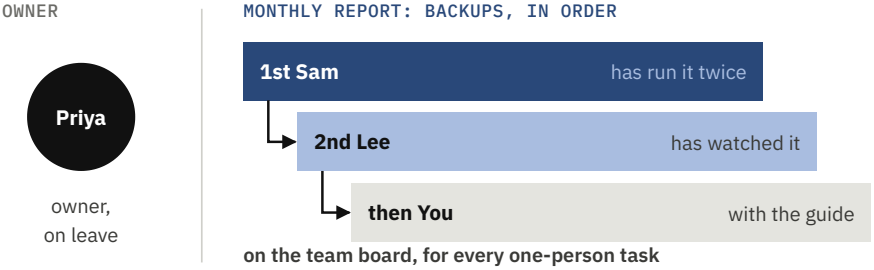
Someone goes on leave, and their task stops.

SOLUTION

01 List the tasks only one person can do.
02 Name a first and second backup for each.
03 Show the order where everyone can see it.

WHY IT WORKS

Cover works when everyone knows who is next.



2.06 THREE PASSES

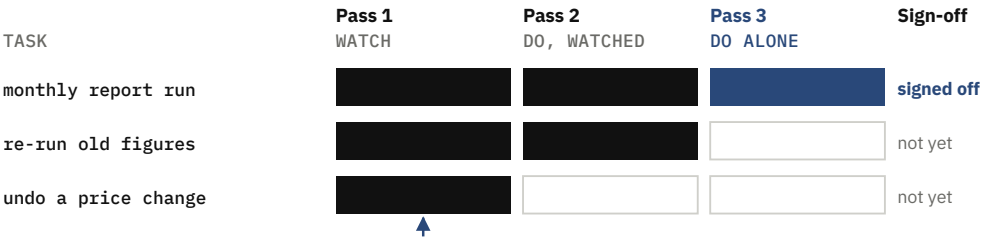
The handover happened, and they still can't do the job.

SOLUTION

01 Hand over each task in three passes.
02 Watch, do while watched, then do alone.
03 Sign off after the solo pass.

WHY IT WORKS

People learn a task by doing it.



2.07 HOSHITORI, SKILLS GRID

See FT 2.05

Four people were trained, and only one can do it alone.

SOLUTION

01 Draw a grid of tasks and people.
02 Mark each cell: alone, with help, or learning.
03 Aim for two people alone on every key task.

WHY IT WORKS

Being trained is not the same as being able.

THE TRAINING RECORD

Supplier payment run

Priya	✓ trained
Sam	✓ trained
Ana	✓ trained
Lee	✓ trained

THE STAR CHART: WHO CAN RUN IT ALONE

	Priya	Sam	Ana	Lee	Alone
Monthly report	●	●	○	◐	**2**
Supplier payments	◐	●	–	○	**1, gap**
Board figures	●	◐	–	–	**1, gap**
Price list update	○	●	●	◐	**2**

● alone ◐ with help ○ learning – not yet

Requests arrive half-filled, so the work comes back.

SOLUTION

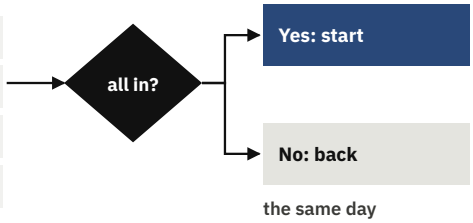
01 List what a complete request must hold.
02 Check each request against it on arrival.
03 Return incomplete ones the same day.

WHY IT WORKS

Gaps are cheapest to fill before the work starts.

A COMPLETE REQUEST HOLDS

What	supplier statement match	✓
Who for	Finance, Priya	✓
By when	**missing**	✗
Files	statement, March	✓



the same day

Logins and key contacts live in one person's head.

SOLUTION

01 List every login and key contact.
02 Keep them in one locked, shared vault.
03 Test a backup login each quarter.

WHY IT WORKS

What only one person knows leaves when they do.

TODAY: IN ONE HEAD

Priya
bank login
payroll login
supplier contacts

on leave: stuck

SHARED VAULT, LOCKED

Item	Owner	Backup
Bank login	Priya	**Sam**
Payroll login	Priya	**Lee**
Supplier contacts	Priya	**Ana**

test one backup login each quarter

2.10 PRE-ARRIVAL

A new starter waits a week for access.

SOLUTION

01 Request access two weeks before they start.
02 Test every login the day before.
03 Plan one thing to learn each day.

WHY IT WORKS

The first week shows a new starter how the team works.

BEFORE DAY ONE

2 weeks before
request all access

Day before
test every login

FIRST WEEK: ONE THING A DAY

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
Team	**Board**	**Report**	**Requests**	**Run it**

doing real work from day one

2.11 TASK ROTATION See HL 4.11

The same person has run the same task for years.

SOLUTION

01 Pick one long-held task each quarter.
02 Rotate it to a second person.
03 The old owner coaches, then steps back.

WHY IT WORKS

The old owner may resist. Say plainly it is about cover.

TODAY: THE PAYMENT RUN

Sam	Sam	Sam	Sam	Sam
2021	2022	2023	2024	2025

one person, five years
nobody else can run it

ROTATE ONE TASK A QUARTER

Sam	Ana	Ana	Lee
Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4

Sam coaches, then steps back

2.12 LEAVER HANDOVER

Someone resigns, and their knowledge walks out.

SOLUTION

01 On notice day, list everything they own.
02 Name a new owner for each item.
03 Hand over in three passes before they go.

WHY IT WORKS

A notice period vanishes fast without a plan.

THE NOTICE PERIOD: FOUR WEEKS



tasks, logins, contacts, open work

watch, do while watched, do alone

their knowledge stays with the team

2.13 LEAVE CALENDAR

Half the team is off the same week.

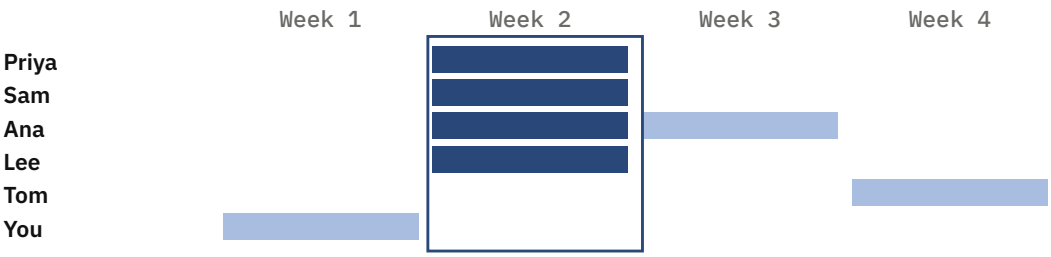
SOLUTION

01 Put all leave on one team calendar.
02 Agree how many can be off at once.
03 Book the busy weeks early.

WHY IT WORKS

Clashes are easy to avoid once leave is visible.

AUGUST, SIX PEOPLE, TWO OFF AT MOST



4 off: over the limit

visible, so easy to move

Updates, Meetings and Decisions

Bad news early, decisions written down.

HŌ-REN-SŌ, AND MEETINGS THAT DECIDE

HŌ-REN-SŌ: THREE FLOWS OF NEWS

報告 **Hōkoku, report** 3.01

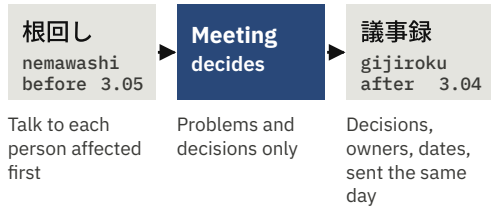
連絡 **Renraku, inform**

相談 **Sōdan, consult** 3.03

HOW THIS TEAM DOES IT

In this team: the written four-line update (3.02)

A DECISION, IN THREE MOMENTS



IN THIS PART

3.01	Hōkoku, report early	15	3.07	Check before you promise	17
3.02	Ketsuron kara, conclusion first	15	3.08	Response times	17
3.03	Sōdan, ask in time	15	3.09	No agenda, no meeting	17
3.04	Gijiroku, meeting record	16	3.10	Action check	18
3.05	Nemawashi, talk first	16	3.11	Meeting reset	18
3.06	Chōrei, short stand-up	16	3.12	Approval wait	18

3.01 HŌKOKU, REPORT EARLY

See FT 6.01 · HL 1.06, 4.01, 4.02, 4.10

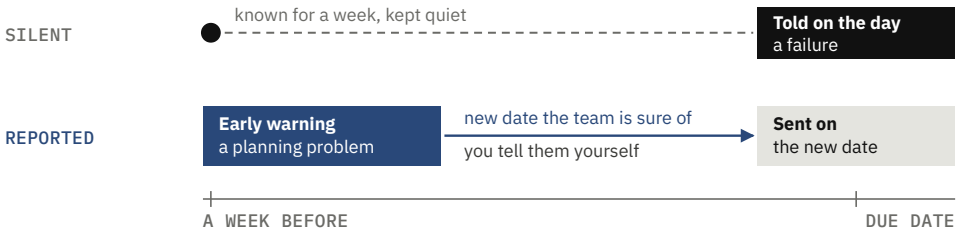
You learn the report is late on the day it is due.

SOLUTION

01 Ask for slips to be reported early.
02 Check due dates together every Monday.
03 Thank the first person who warns you.

WHY IT WORKS

People share bad news when it is never held against them later.



3.02 KETSURON KARA, CONCLUSION FIRST

See FT 6.01

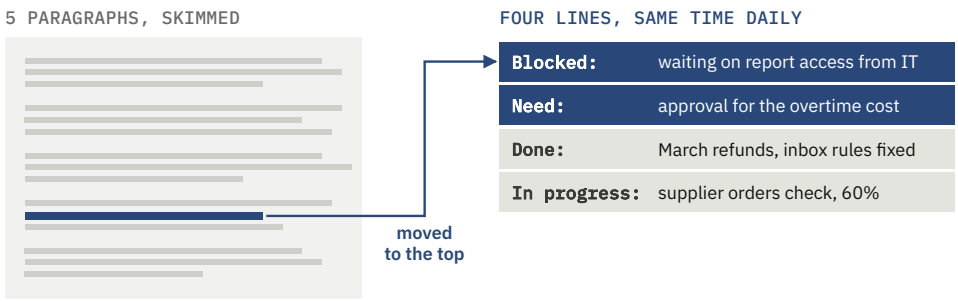
Updates bury the point, and readers miss it.

SOLUTION

01 Put the conclusion or the ask first.
02 Add the reasons below, briefly.
03 For daily status, use four fixed lines.

WHY IT WORKS

Readers act on what they see first.



3.03 SŌDAN, ASK IN TIME

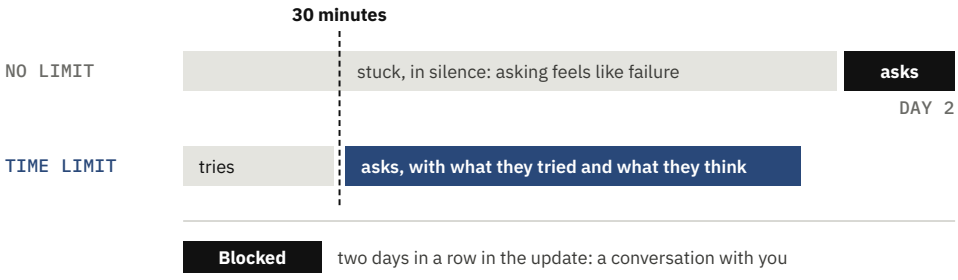
Someone was stuck for days before asking.

SOLUTION

01 Agree a time limit, say 30 minutes.
02 After that, they ask for help.
03 They bring what they tried.

WHY IT WORKS

A time limit takes the shame out of asking.



3.04 GIJIROKU, MEETING RECORD

See HL 7.03, 8.01

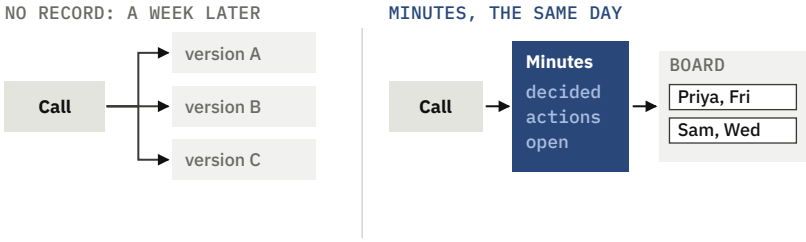
The call ends, and nobody agrees on what was decided.

SOLUTION

01 Someone takes notes in every meeting.
02 Read the decisions out before the end.
03 Send decisions, owners and dates that day.

WHY IT WORKS

Memories of a meeting drift apart within days.



3.05 NEMAWASHI, TALK FIRST

See FT 2.06 · HL 7.01

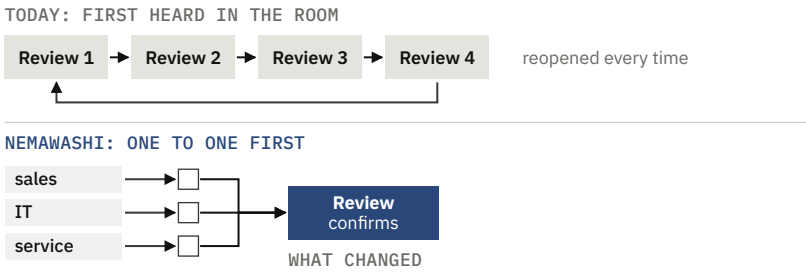
The same decision gets reopened at every review.

SOLUTION

01 Talk to each affected person before the meeting.
02 Change the proposal with what you hear.
03 Use the meeting to confirm.

WHY IT WORKS

A decision gets reopened when the decider was not on board.



3.06 CHŌREI, SHORT STAND-UP

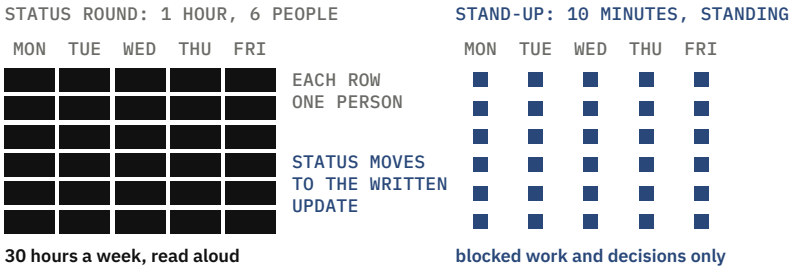
The stand-up runs long, and people drift off.

SOLUTION

01 Keep it to ten minutes, standing.
02 Talk only about blocked work.
03 Take long topics to a separate call.

WHY IT WORKS

A short meeting holds people's attention.



3.07 CHECK BEFORE YOU PROMISE

You gave a date before asking the team.

SOLUTION

01 Say you will confirm a date tomorrow.
02 Ask the people who will do the work.
03 Then give the date.

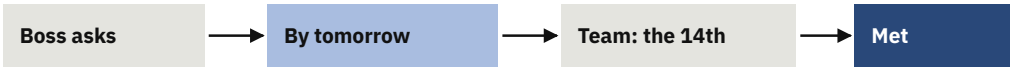
WHY IT WORKS

People keep dates they helped to set.

TODAY



CHECK FIRST



3.08 RESPONSE TIMES

Late and weekend messages keep coming.

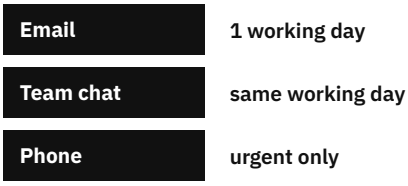
SOLUTION

01 Agree a reply time for each channel.
02 Use scheduled send after hours.
03 Agree what counts as truly urgent.

WHY IT WORKS

People copy the most senior sender. If your boss sends at night, they reply at night.

AGREED REPLY TIMES



AFTER HOURS



scheduled send
no reply expected tonight

3.09 NO AGENDA, NO MEETING

Meetings run long and decide nothing.

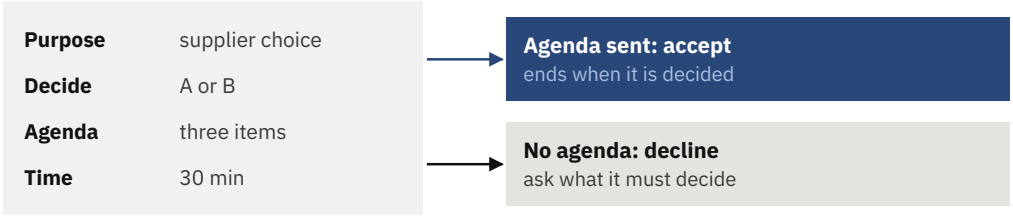
SOLUTION

01 Send an agenda with every invite.
02 Name the decision the meeting must make.
03 Ask seniors for an agenda, and decline peers without one.

WHY IT WORKS

A meeting with a stated goal can end when it is met.

THE INVITE



3.10 ACTION CHECK

Actions agreed in meetings never get done.

SOLUTION

01 Give each action one owner and a date.
02 Open the next meeting with the action list.
03 Each owner says done or a new date.

WHY IT WORKS

People finish what they know will be checked.

NEXT MEETING, FIRST FIVE MINUTES

Action	Owner	Due	Status
Send the new price list	Priya	3 Mar	**done**
Book the supplier review	Sam	5 Mar	**new date: 12 Mar**
Fix the order form	Lee	6 Mar	**done**

one owner, one date, read out every time

3.11 MEETING RESET

The calendar is full of meetings nobody would book today.

SOLUTION

01 Each quarter, list every repeating meeting.
02 Cancel any without a clear purpose.
03 Rebook only the ones people missed.

WHY IT WORKS

Repeating meetings go on because nobody questions them.

REPEATING MEETINGS, THIS QUARTER

Monday status	cancelled
Project sync	kept
Weekly catch-up	cancelled
Supplier review	kept
Report walk-through	cancelled

HOURS A WEEK



3.12 APPROVAL WAIT

Finished work waits days for a checker or approver.

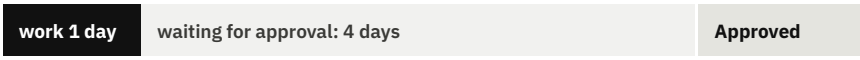
SOLUTION

01 Name the approver when the work starts.
02 Ask approvers for a reply date, and chase in person.
03 Show waiting approvals on the board.

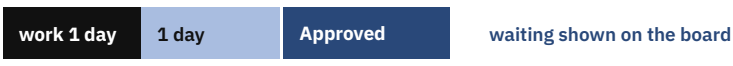
WHY IT WORKS

Waiting work stays invisible until someone shows it.

TODAY: FIVE DAYS



APPROVER NAMED, ONE DAY



Workload and Flow

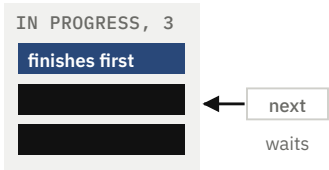
Take on only what the team can finish.

DEMAND, WORK IN PROGRESS AND THE WORKING DAY

1. DEMAND AGAINST CAPACITY



2. LIMIT OPEN WORK 4.02



3. THE WORKING DAY

定時 **Teiji** 4.03

残業 **Zangyō**

平準化 **Heijunka** 4.04

IN THIS PART

4.01	Demand, capacity	20
4.02	WIP limit	20
4.03	Teiji, log-off time	20
4.04	Heijunka, level the load	21
4.05	Yutori, reserve capacity	21
4.06	Oldest job first	21
4.07	Small batches	22
4.08	Tōban, duty rota	22
4.09	One priority order	22
4.10	Key dates	23
4.11	Cut-off time	23

4.01 DEMAND, CAPACITY

The team says yes to everything, and work piles up.

SOLUTION

01 Count the hours asked for on the intake list.
02 Count the hours the team has.
03 Too much? Your boss picks what waits, confirmed by email.

WHY IT WORKS

Numbers make it harder to say yes to everything. Someone still has to say no.

THIS WEEK, IN HOURS



SAID OUT LOUD: WHAT WAITS

Audit prep: next week **New report: May** from the intake list

4.02 WIP LIMIT See FT 5.03

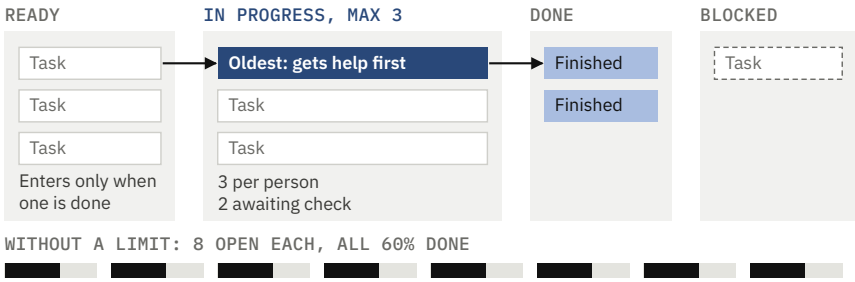
Everyone has too many jobs open, and nothing gets finished.

SOLUTION

01 Allow three open jobs per person.
02 Finish one before starting another.

WHY IT WORKS

Switching between jobs wastes more time than it feels.



4.03 TEIJI, LOG-OFF TIME

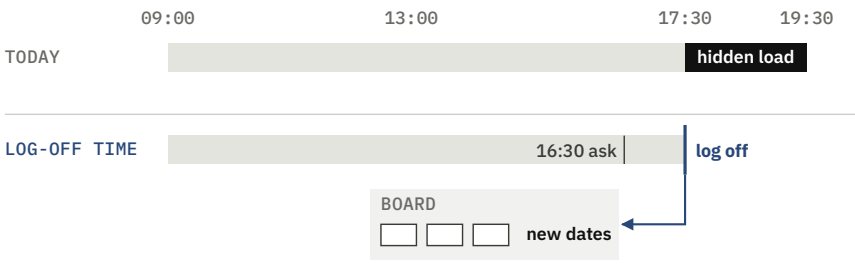
People work late every day, and the work still grows.

SOLUTION

01 Agree a time to log off.
02 Leave on time yourself.
03 Unfinished work waits for tomorrow.

WHY IT WORKS

People copy what gets rewarded. If late stayers get promoted, they stay late.



4.04 HEIJUNKA, LEVEL THE LOAD

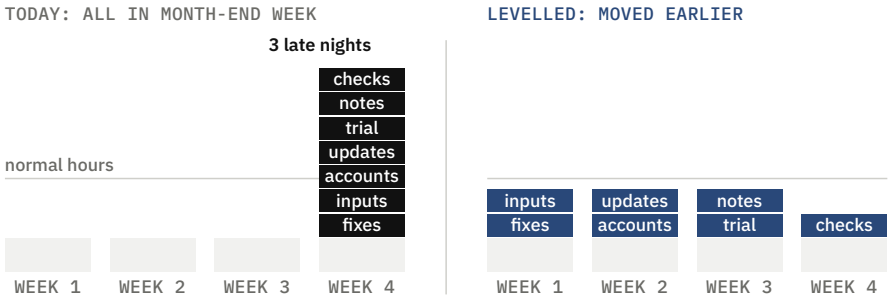
Every month-end means late nights.

SOLUTION

01 List the month-end tasks.
02 Move one task earlier each month.

WHY IT WORKS

Small steady work beats one big rush.



4.05 YUTORI, RESERVE CAPACITY

See FT 4.03

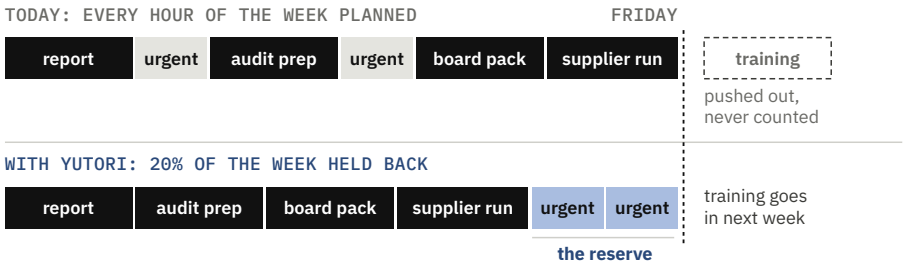
Urgent requests push planned work aside.

SOLUTION

01 Keep 20% of each week unplanned.
02 Plan only the rest.
03 Write down what came in.

WHY IT WORKS

A plan with no room breaks at the first surprise.



4.06 OLDEST JOB FIRST

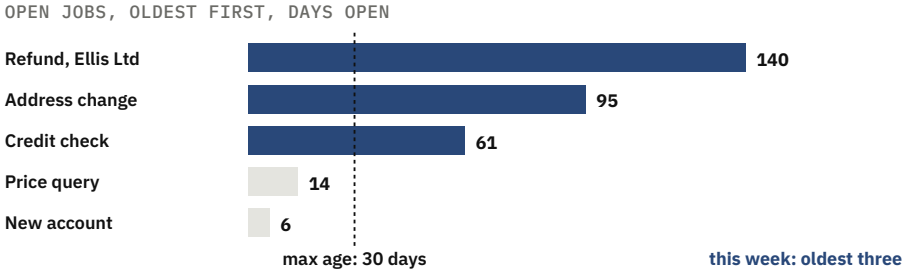
Old jobs sit open for months.

SOLUTION

01 Sort open jobs by age, oldest first.
02 Finish or close the oldest three each week.
03 Agree a maximum age for any job.

WHY IT WORKS

New work always feels more urgent than old work.



4.07 SMALL BATCHES

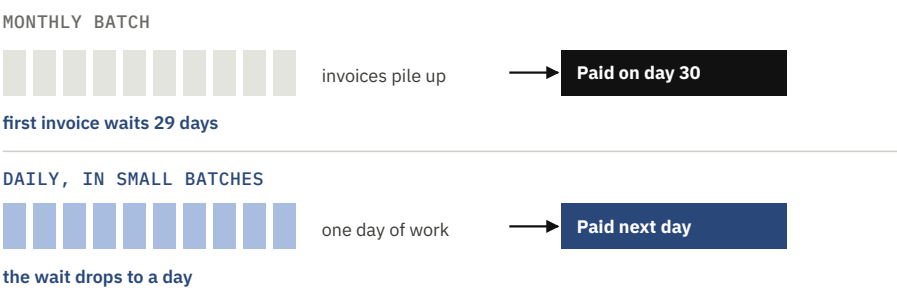
Work waits to be done in bulk.

SOLUTION

01 Find work saved up for one big run.
02 Do it daily or weekly instead.
03 Watch the waiting time drop.

WHY IT WORKS

In a batch, the first item waits for the last.



4.08 TŌBAN, DUTY ROTA

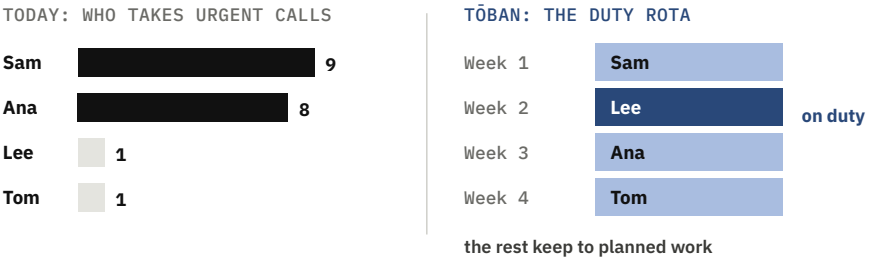
The same two people take every urgent call.

SOLUTION

01 Set a weekly duty rota for interruptions.
02 The person on duty takes every urgent call.
03 Everyone else keeps to planned work.

WHY IT WORKS

Without a rota, the most helpful people take everything.



4.09 ONE PRIORITY ORDER

See FT 4.03

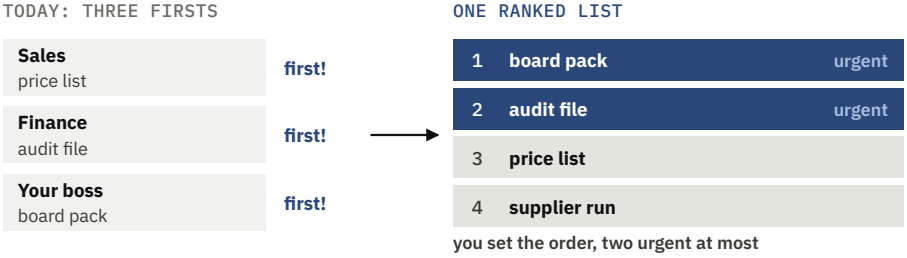
Three people each say their job comes first.

SOLUTION

01 Keep one ranked list for the team.
02 The boss all three answer to sets the order.
03 Allow two urgent items a week at most.

WHY IT WORKS

Without one order, the loudest request wins.



4.10 KEY DATES

A renewal date was remembered the day before.

SOLUTION

01 Put every fixed date on one team calendar.
02 Give each an owner and a start date.
03 Review the next 90 days every Monday.

WHY IT WORKS

A date nobody owns gets remembered too late.

TEAM CALENDAR: THE NEXT 90 DAYS

Date	What	Owner	Start
30 Nov	**Insurance renewal**	Priya	**1 Nov**
31 Dec	**Year-end payroll**	Sam	**1 Dec**
31 Jan	**Tax return filed**	You	**2 Jan**

reviewed every Monday

4.11 CUT-OFF TIME

Late requests get squeezed in, and the batch goes wrong.

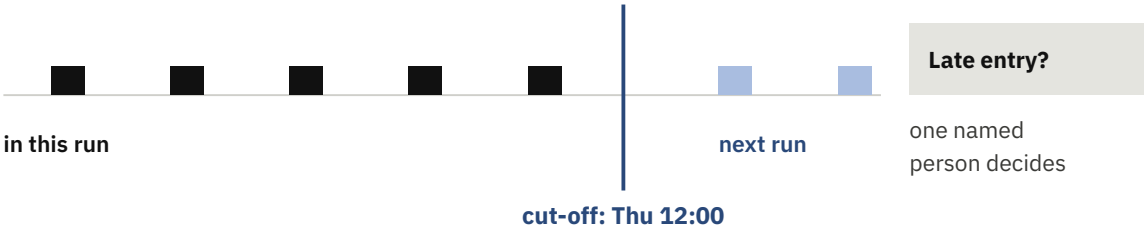
SOLUTION

01 Publish one cut-off time for each run.
02 Later requests go into the next run.
03 One named person approves any late entry.

WHY IT WORKS

A firm line stops the rush at the end.

WEEKLY PRICE UPDATE



When Things Go Wrong

Stop the damage, tell people, fix the cause.

STOP, CALL, FIX THE CAUSE

Stop	Call	Contain	Fix	Prevent
自働化 jidoka	アンドン andon			再発防止 saihatsu bōshi
Stop when something looks wrong	Raise it straight away	Protect customers first: undo it	Find the causes: 5 Whys for each one	Change the standard

IN THIS PART

5.01	Jidoka, andon: stop and signal	25	5.05	Kunren, the drill	26
5.02	Saihatsu bōshi, prevent a repeat	25	5.06	Go-live check	26
5.03	Shohō, first report	25	5.07	Silent failure	27
5.04	Person in charge	26	5.08	Workaround list	27

5.01 JIDOKA, ANDON: STOP AND SIGNAL

An error is spotted and passed on anyway.

SOLUTION

01 Whoever spots an error stops work and signals at once.
02 You take the blame for the delay.
03 Fix it where it started.

WHY IT WORKS

A problem is cheapest the moment someone sees it.

PASSED ON



STOP AND SIGNAL



5.02 SAIHATSU BŌSHI, PREVENT A REPEAT

See FT 2.04 · HL 4.03

The same failure keeps coming back.

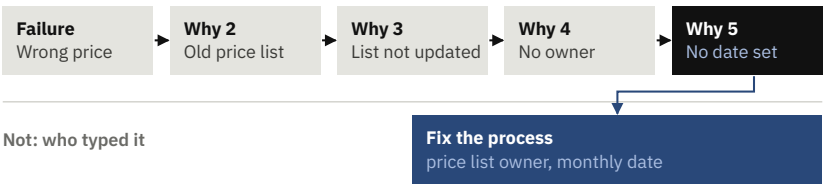
SOLUTION

01 Ask why, five times.
02 Fix what the process allowed.
03 Keep names out of the write-up that goes upward.

WHY IT WORKS

Blame stops people reporting the next problem.

ASK WHY, FIVE TIMES: A WRONG INVOICE



5.03 SHOHŌ, FIRST REPORT

See HL 3.06, 8.02

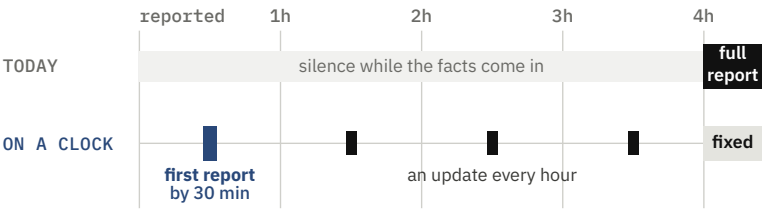
A wrong price went out, and customers heard nothing.

SOLUTION

01 Agree now who may send a first report without sign-off.
02 Update every hour until it is fixed.
03 Each update says when the next comes.

WHY IT WORKS

Silence worries people more than bad news.



5.04 PERSON IN CHARGE

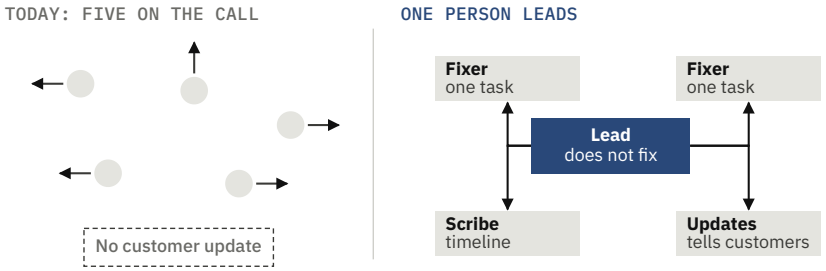
Payroll ran wrong, and nobody is leading the fix.

SOLUTION

01 Name one person in charge.
02 They assign the work and send updates.
03 They do not fix it themselves.

WHY IT WORKS

Without a lead, people repeat work and forget updates.



5.05 KUNREN, THE DRILL

See FT 4.04

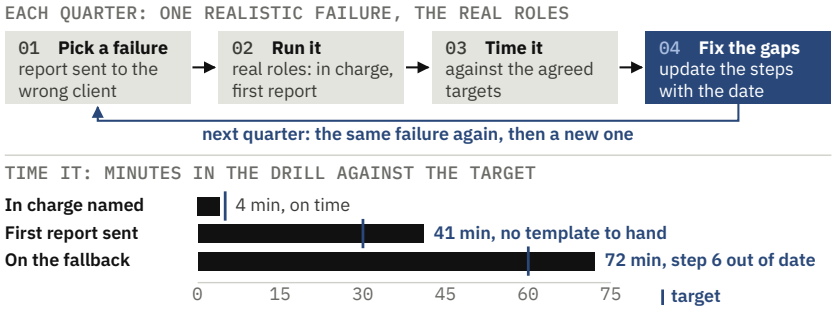
The plan for failures has never been tried.

SOLUTION

01 Each quarter, rehearse one realistic failure.
02 Use the real roles and time it.
03 Fix what the drill shows within a week.

WHY IT WORKS

Under pressure, people do what they have practised.



5.06 GO-LIVE CHECK

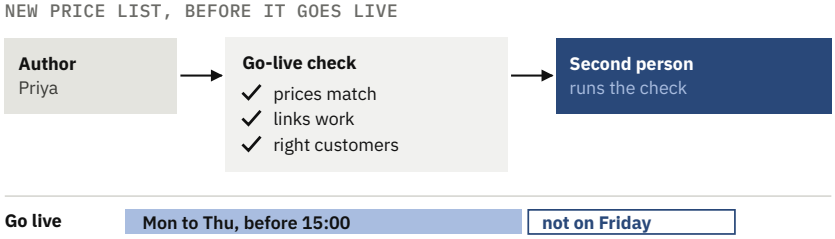
A mistake went live, and customers found it first.

SOLUTION

01 Write a short check for every go-live.
02 A second person runs it before launch.
03 No go-lives after 15:00 or on Fridays.

WHY IT WORKS

A fresh pair of eyes sees what the author misses.



5.07 SILENT FAILURE

The overnight report did not run, and nobody noticed.

SOLUTION

01 List every job that runs unattended.
02 Make each one send a done message.
03 Check for the done messages each morning.

WHY IT WORKS

Silence looks the same as success.

TODAY: NO NEWS LOOKS LIKE GOOD NEWS

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
ran	ran	failed	failed	failed

found next Monday

EVERY JOB SENDS A DONE MESSAGE

Mon	Tue	Wed
✓	✓	?

no done message by 08:00: chase it

5.08 WORKAROUND LIST

Temporary fixes and private spreadsheets became permanent.

SOLUTION

01 List every workaround, and promise nobody is blamed for one.
02 Give each an owner and an end date.
03 Fix the cause, or make it the standard.

WHY IT WORKS

A workaround nobody lists never gets fixed.

THE WORKAROUND LIST

Workaround	Owner	End date	Decision
Sam's discount sheet	Sam	30 Apr	**into the system**
Manual VAT fix	Priya	15 May	**fix the cause**
Copy-paste order log	Lee	31 May	**make it standard**

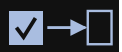
reviewed monthly, nothing stays temporary

Quality at the Source

Get it right at each step.

QUALITY BUILT IN AT EACH STEP

自工程完結
Jikōtei kanketsu



初物検査
First piece,
hatsumono kensa



ポカヨケ
Poka-yoke



IN THIS PART

6.01	Right first time	29
6.02	Done card	29
6.03	Jikōtei kanketsu, own your step	29
6.04	Hatsumono, first-piece check	30
6.05	Poka-yoke, mistake-proofing	30
6.06	Failure demand	30
6.07	Supplier quality	31
6.08	Named sign-offs	31

6.01 RIGHT FIRST TIME

Work comes back for fixes all the time.

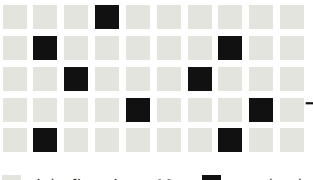
SOLUTION

01 Tally each item as right first time or sent back.
02 Tag the cause of each return.
03 Fix the top cause first.

WHY IT WORKS

A count shows which cause costs most.

ONE MONTH, ONE KEY OUTPUT: 50 ITEMS



Tally it
right first time or sent back, one cause tag

41 of 50: 82% right first time
review monthly

Take the top cause tag
run the 5 Whys on it this week

6.02 DONE CARD

You polish work for days, and it still comes back short.

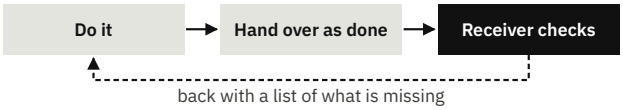
SOLUTION

01 Before starting, ask what the work is for.
02 Agree three to five checks.
03 Stop when they pass.

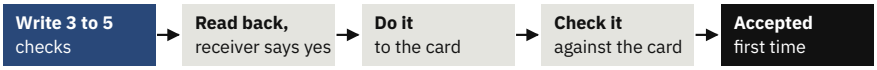
WHY IT WORKS

Done means different things until it is written down.

WITHOUT A CARD: DONE MEANS TWO THINGS



WITH A DONE CARD AGREED BEFORE STARTING



6.03 JIKŌTEI KANKETSU, OWN YOUR STEP

The checker rewrites the work instead of returning it.

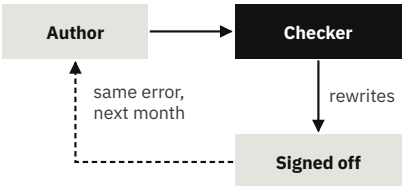
SOLUTION

01 The checker marks errors without fixing them.
02 Send the work back to the author.
03 The author fixes it.

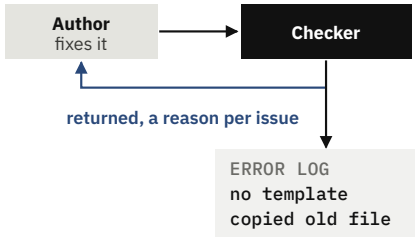
WHY IT WORKS

People improve when they fix their own mistakes.

CHECKER FIXES IT QUIETLY



SENT BACK TO THE SOURCE



6.04 HATSUMONO, FIRST-PIECE CHECK

300 letters went out with the same error.

SOLUTION

01 Check the first item of every batch fully.
02 Run the rest only after it passes.

WHY IT WORKS

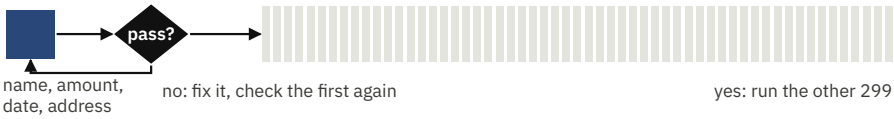
One wrong setting repeats in every copy.

RUN ALL 300, LOOK AFTERWARDS



300 letters, the same wrong date in every one

CHECK THE FIRST PIECE, THEN RUN THE REST



6.05 POKA-YOKE, MISTAKE-PROOFING

Figures are retyped between systems, and typos reach customers.

SOLUTION

01 Never retype data that already exists.
02 Use links and drop-down lists.
03 Add checks that block wrong entries.

WHY IT WORKS

A mistake that cannot happen needs no checking.

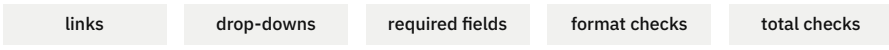
RETYPED



DESIGNED OUT



CHECKS THAT MAKE THE MISTAKE IMPOSSIBLE



6.06 FAILURE DEMAND

Customers keep chasing and correcting your work.

SOLUTION

01 For two weeks, tag every customer contact.
02 Mark the ones your team caused.
03 Fix the biggest type first.

WHY IT WORKS

Most chasers are work the team made for itself.

CUSTOMER CONTACTS, TWO WEEKS: 400



6.07 SUPPLIER QUALITY

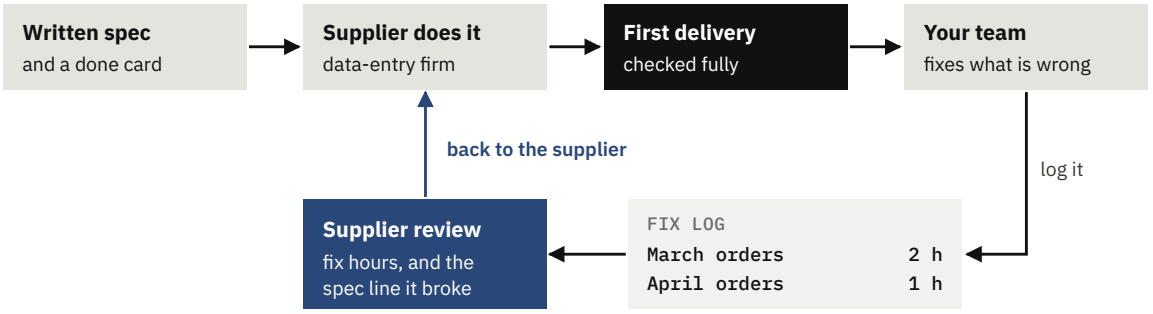
A supplier's work arrives wrong, and your team quietly fixes it.

SOLUTION

01 Give the supplier a written spec.
02 Check their first delivery fully.
03 Log every fix and send errors back.

WHY IT WORKS

Suppliers fix what their contract owner chases. Send your log there.



6.08 NAMED SIGN-OFFS

Three people approve it, and errors still get through.

SOLUTION

01 Give each sign-off named items to check.
02 Drop any sign-off with nothing to check.
03 Each signer initials their own items.

WHY IT WORKS

Each checker assumes another one looked closely.

TODAY: THREE SIGNATURES

Priya	looked at it
Sam	looked at it
You	looked at it

the error gets through

EACH SIGNS FOR NAMED ITEMS

Priya	**figures**
Sam	**names, addresses**
You	**prices**

Running the Team

See the work every day, and lead by routine.

SEE, ESCALATE, LEAD

01 See → **02 Escalate** → **03 Lead**

A team board with three measures, read daily

Blockers go up a tier within 24 hours, answers come back

Your own standard work, a weekly gemba walk, coaching questions

IN THIS PART

7.01	Mieruka, team board	32	7.05	Gemba walk	34
7.02	Tiered huddles	33	7.06	Coaching kata	34
7.03	Leader work	33	7.07	One-to-ones	34
7.04	Hoshin kanri, goals into work	33			

7.01 MIERUKA, TEAM BOARD

See HL 8.03

There is a dashboard, and nobody looks at it.

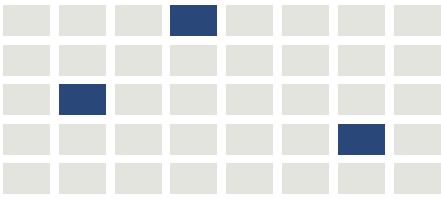
SOLUTION

01 Put up one board per team.
02 Show three measures the team can change.
03 Start the stand-up at the board.

WHY IT WORKS

People watch the board while you use it daily. Skip a week and it dies.

REPORT DASHBOARD: 40 PANELS



the three anyone acted on: keep
the rest: delete

TEAM BOARD: THREE MEASURES, READ DAILY

MEASURE	TARGET	NOW	STATUS
Requests on time	95%	91%	RED
Right first time	95%	97%	GREEN
Oldest open request	5 days	9 days	RED

The stand-up starts at the board
Test: anyone can say what is red this week

7.02 TIERED HUDDLES

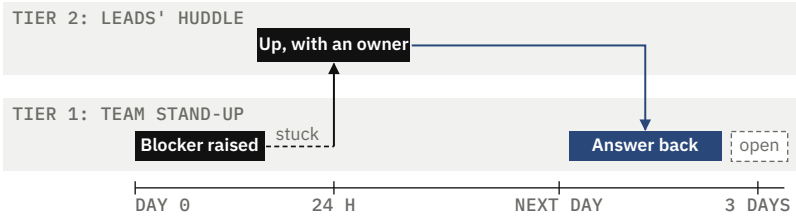
The same blocker comes up at every stand-up.

SOLUTION

01 Send any blocker older than a day up one level.
02 Give it an owner.
03 Bring the answer back the next day.

WHY IT WORKS

A problem needs somewhere to go.



7.03 LEADER WORK

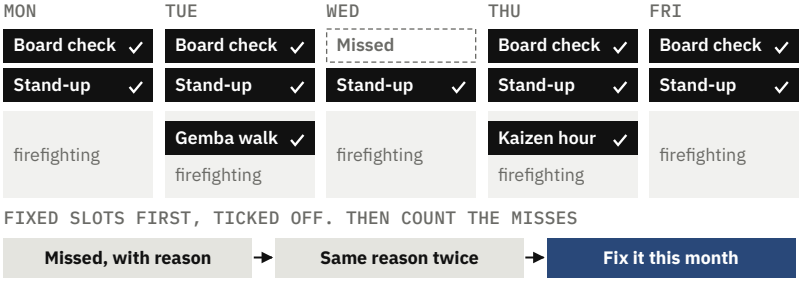
Firefighting fills your week, and your own routines get skipped.

SOLUTION

01 Write your daily, weekly and monthly routines on one page.
02 Give each a fixed slot.
03 Tick them off.

WHY IT WORKS

Routines with a booked slot survive busy weeks.



7.04 HOSHIN KANRI, GOALS INTO WORK See FT 5.01

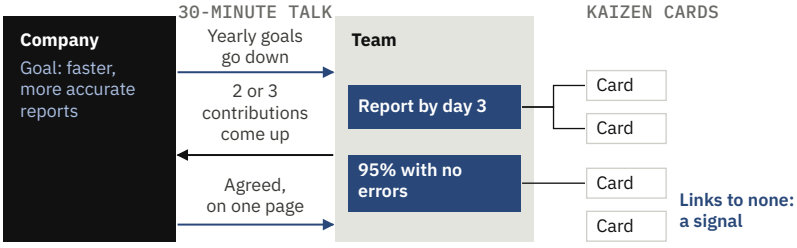
Nobody on the team can name this year's priorities.

SOLUTION

01 Take the yearly goals to the team.
02 Agree two or three things you will do.
03 Write them on one page, knowing the goals won't change.

WHY IT WORKS

Goals only matter once they become team work.



7.05 GEMBA WALK

You only see the real work when something breaks.

SOLUTION

01 Spend 30 minutes a week watching real work.
02 Ask what makes it hard.
03 Fix one thing that week.

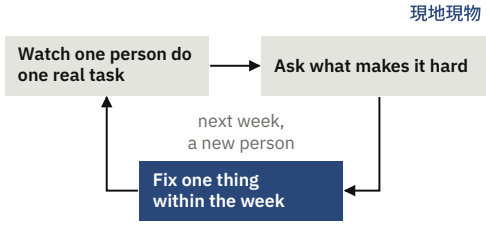
WHY IT WORKS

People act differently while you watch. Go often enough to be ordinary.

TODAY: THROUGH REPORTS



GEMBA WALK: GO AND SEE, 30 MIN A WEEK



7.06 COACHING KATA

See FT 7.03

Your team brings you every problem to solve.

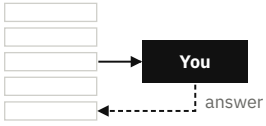
SOLUTION

01 Ask questions before giving your view.
02 Let them answer, even slowly.
03 Ask what they will try next.

WHY IT WORKS

Each answer you give teaches them to ask again.

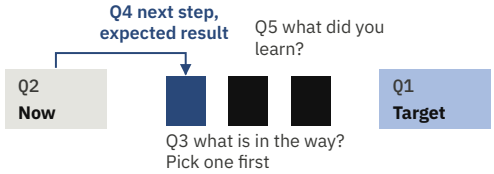
TODAY: YOU ANSWER



a queue, every day

Each answer brings the next problem

COACHING KATA: THEY FIND THE WAY



7.07 ONE-TO-ONES

See FT 6.02 · HL 1.02, 2.04

Your one-to-ones have become status updates.

SOLUTION

01 Keep one running document per person.
02 They write their topics first.
03 You add one coaching question.

WHY IT WORKS

People open up as far as they trust you. You also rate them.

BEFORE: 30 MINUTES



AFTER: THEIR HALF HOUR, IN A FIXED ORDER



Running doc, one per person
they write first, before the meeting

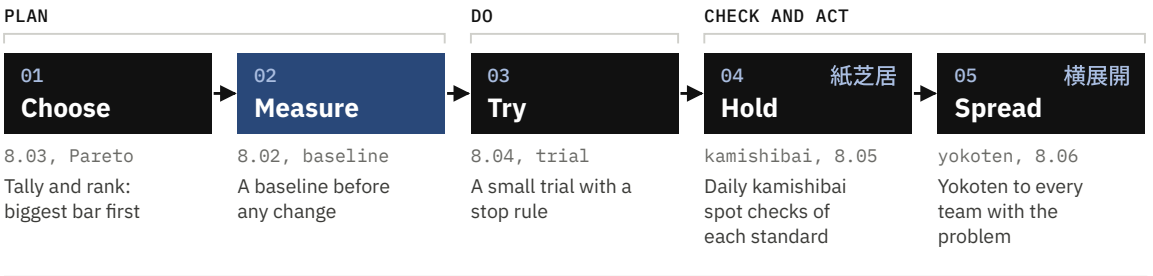


Status moves to the board
opener: what do you want to cover?

Improving and Sustaining

Measure first, change small, make it last.

IMPROVEMENT THAT LASTS



IN THIS PART

8.01	Kaizen card	36
8.02	Baseline	36
8.03	Pareto tally	36
8.04	Small trial	37
8.05	Kamishibai, daily spot check	37
8.06	Yokoten, share sideways	37
8.07	Hansei, look back	38
8.08	Value stream	38
8.09	Kaizen hour	38
8.10	Problem first	39
8.11	Changed and told	39
8.12	Stop doing	39

8.01 KAIZEN CARD

Ideas come up in every review, and nothing happens.

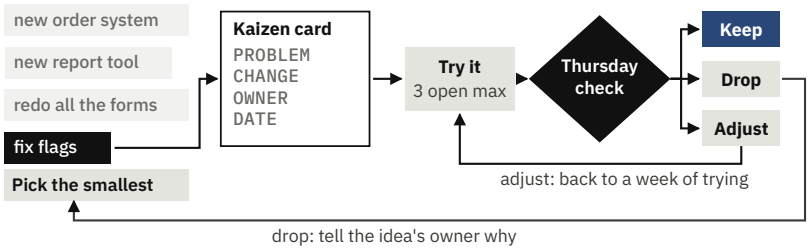
SOLUTION

01 Put each idea on a small card with an owner.
02 Answer every idea within a week.
03 Tell the person what happened.

WHY IT WORKS

People stop suggesting when nothing changes. Do the small ones fast.

IDEAS LIST



8.02 BASELINE See HL 4.06, 4.12, 8.08

A change was made, and nobody can say if it helped.

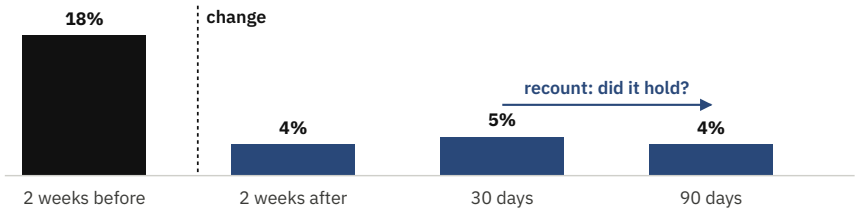
SOLUTION

01 Count the problem for two weeks first.
02 Make the change, then count again.
03 Recount at 30 and 90 days.

WHY IT WORKS

Without a before, any after looks good.

ORDERS SENT BACK, % OF ORDERS



8.03 PARETO TALLY See FT 4.02

The loudest complaint got fixed, and the costliest one didn't.

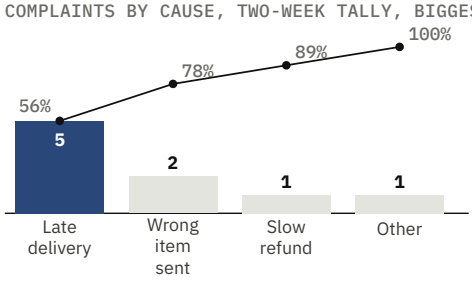
SOLUTION

01 Tally problems by cause for two weeks.
02 Rank them, biggest first.
03 Fix the biggest one.

WHY IT WORKS

The loudest is rarely the biggest. If your boss raised it, fix both.

COMPLAINTS BY CAUSE, TWO-WEEK TALLY, BIGGEST FIRST



FIX FIRST
5 of 9 complaints

8.04 SMALL TRIAL See FT 5.04

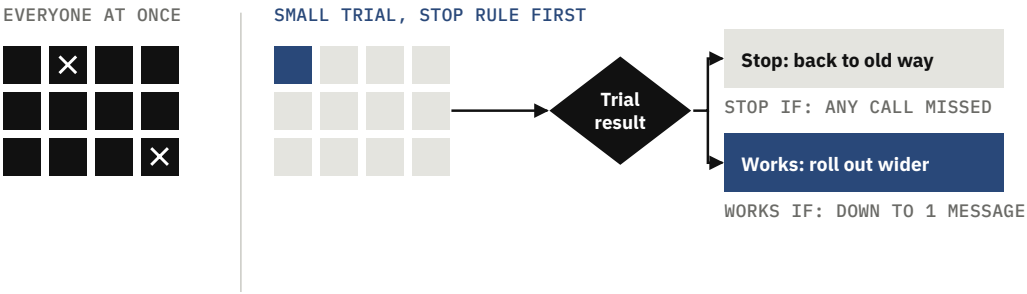
A change went to everyone at once, and something broke.

SOLUTION

01 Try the change on one team first.
02 Write down what result stops it.
03 Roll out only if it holds.

WHY IT WORKS

A small test fails cheaply.



8.05 KAMISHIBAI, DAILY SPOT CHECK See FT Stage 7

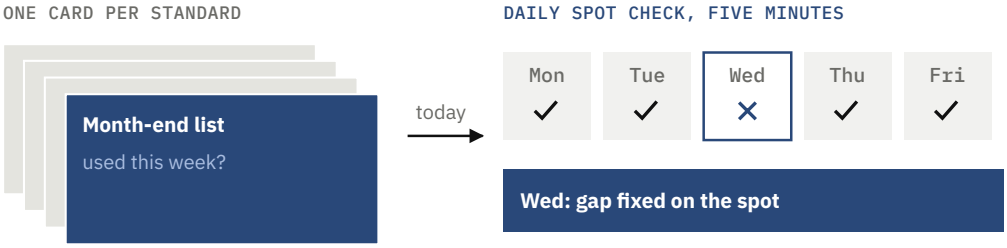
People slowly drift back to the old way.

SOLUTION

01 Keep one check card per standard.
02 Draw one card each day and check.
03 Fix any gap on the spot.

WHY IT WORKS

Old habits creep back when nobody checks.



8.06 YOKOTEN, SHARE SIDEWAYS

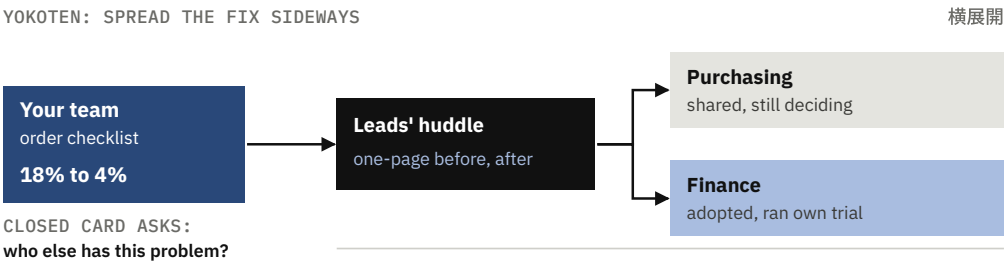
Another team solved your problem last year, and nobody told you.

SOLUTION

01 For every fix, ask who else has this problem.
02 Share a one-page before and after.
03 Swap fixes with other leads each quarter.

WHY IT WORKS

Other teams take a fix that saves them effort. Lead with hours saved.



8.07 HANSEI, LOOK BACK

See HL 8.06

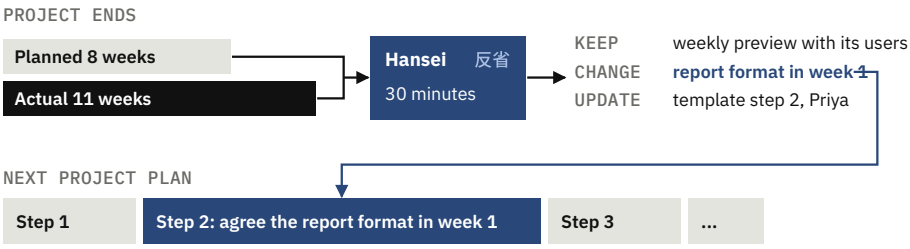
The project ended, and nobody asked what to change next time.

SOLUTION

01 Book 30 minutes when a project ends.
02 Name one thing to keep and one to change.
03 Update one guide or template.

WHY IT WORKS

Lessons last only when they change a guide people use.



8.08 VALUE STREAM

See FT 2.04

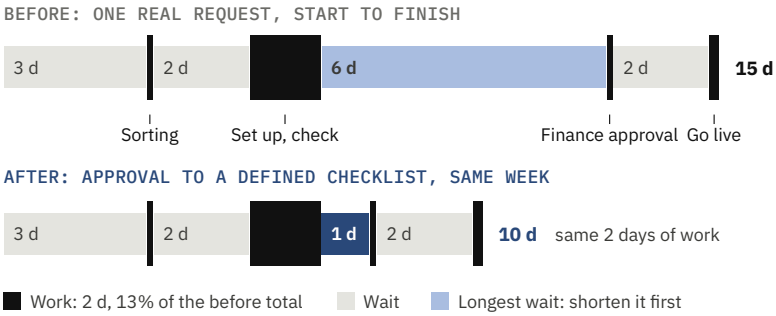
A request takes three weeks, and the work takes two days.

SOLUTION

01 Follow one real request from start to finish.
02 Note the work time and the wait at each step.
03 Cut the longest wait first.

WHY IT WORKS

Most delay is work sitting in a queue.



8.09 KAIZEN HOUR

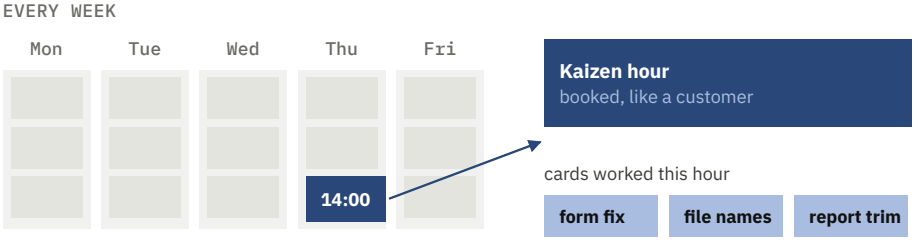
Improvement waits for a quiet week that never comes.

SOLUTION

01 Book one hour a week for improvement.
02 Work the kaizen cards in that hour.
03 Protect it like a customer meeting.

WHY IT WORKS

A booked hour still loses to the urgent. Refuse to move it.



8.10 PROBLEM FIRST

The problem statement is really a solution in disguise.

SOLUTION

01 Write the problem without naming a fix.
02 Say what happens, where and how often.
03 Only then list possible fixes.

WHY IT WORKS

A named fix stops people looking for the cause.

A FIX IN DISGUISE

We need a new system ✕

THE PROBLEM FIRST

Orders wait 3 days
for approval, 40 a week

→

THEN THE FIXES

Raise	**Name**	**New**
the limit	one approver	system

8.11 CHANGED AND TOLD

See FT 5.04

The process changed, and half the team works the old way.

SOLUTION

01 Tell everyone what changed and why.
02 Show the new way, then watch them try.
03 Check each person after one week.

WHY IT WORKS

People keep the old way if it is easier. Keep checking.

CHANGED BY EMAIL



3 of 6 on the new way

TOLD, SHOWN, CHECKED

Told	what and why
Shown	then they try
Checked	after a week



6 of 6

8.12 STOP DOING

The weekly report takes a day, and nobody reads it.

SOLUTION

01 List every regular report and task.
02 Pause one for a month.
03 Stop it for good if nobody asks.

WHY IT WORKS

Work carries on because nobody asked to stop it.

WEEKLY REPORT: 8 HOURS

Pause it
for four weeks

→

W1	W2	W3	W4
0	**0**	**0**	**0**

→

Stopped
8 h back

people who asked for it

If someone asks: bring back only the part they use

S Situations

Real problems need more than one routine. Each situation is three steps, in order.

	SITUATION, AND THE PARTS IT DRAWS ON	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	Page
TAKING OVER AND CHANGING HOW WORK IS DONE										S.01 to S.06
S.01	See where it stands first			■	■			■		41
S.02	Plan for it and cut it down		■		■				■	41
S.03	Move them in safe waves	■			■				■	41
S.04	Make them one team			■				■		41
S.05	Agree on one standard	■		■					■	41
S.06	Get them handling real requests in four weeks		■					■	■	42
WHEN WORK PILES UP										S.07 to S.12
S.07	Get it checked within a working day			■	■		■	■		42
S.08	Cut to the ones that matter								■	42
S.09	Clear out the rest without breaking anything	■	■				■			42
S.10	Turn repeat requests into self-service		■				■		■	42
S.11	Spread the load		■		■					43
S.12	Fix it at the source					■	■			43
WHEN THINGS GO WRONG										S.13 to S.18
S.13	Fix how changes go live	■	■			■			■	43
S.14	Make failures loud					■				43
S.15	Lead it, then fix the process					■	■			43
S.16	Plan the fallback in advance	■	■			■				44
S.17	Make it safe to change	■	■					■		44
S.18	Find the cost and cut it						■	■	■	44
WORKING WITH OTHER TEAMS										S.19 to S.24
S.19	Settle it once		■	■						44
S.20	Make changes arrive with warning		■				■			44
S.21	Find out and keep it current		■						■	45
S.22	Stop it happening twice			■		■		■		45
S.23	Give each one an owner and a clean hand-off		■				■			45
S.24	Hear it first next time					■		■		45

S.01 See where it stands first

Taking over and changing how work is done

YOU SEE — You inherit a team mid-project. The date is fixed.

1	Sit with each person and the work.	7.05
2	Count what is left and the weekly rate.	4.01
3	Take your boss options on scope and people. The date will stay.	3.03

S.02 Plan for it and cut it down

Taking over and changing how work is done

YOU SEE — Unplanned work eats 40% of every month.

1	Tag and rank unplanned work by source.	8.03
2	Send all requests through one way in.	2.03
3	Hold a steady reserve for the rest.	4.04 · 4.05

S.03 Move them in safe waves

Taking over and changing how work is done

YOU SEE — The team must move to a new system.

1	Retire the reports nobody reads.	1.01
2	Move a small pilot wave first.	8.04
3	Move the rest in steady weekly waves.	4.04

S.04 Make them one team

Taking over and changing how work is done

YOU SEE — Two merged teams work in different ways.

1	Put all the work on one board.	7.01
2	Hold one stand-up from week one.	3.06
3	Settle one difference a week, in writing.	3.04

S.05 Agree on one standard

Taking over and changing how work is done

YOU SEE — Five offices run one process five ways.

1	Compare the five ways on one page.	8.06
2	Get the boss over all five leads to back it.	3.05
3	Write one standard with the people who do it.	1.03

S.06 Get them handling real requests in four weeks

Taking over and changing how work is done

YOU SEE New starters take three months to be useful.

1	Teach the most common request types first.	8.03
2	Teach each type in three passes.	2.06
3	Track progress on a skills grid.	2.07 · 7.01

S.07 Get it checked within a working day

When work piles up

YOU SEE Work waits days for a second check.

1	Show waiting checks on the board, oldest first.	7.01 · 3.12
2	Clear one check before starting new work.	4.02
3	Ask authors to check their own work first.	6.03

S.08 Cut to the ones that matter

When work piles up

YOU SEE The team gets 300 warnings a week. Most are ignored.

1	Tally a week of warnings by rule.	8.03
2	Trial cutting the top rules on one group.	8.04
3	Recount at 30 and 90 days.	8.02

S.09 Clear out the rest without breaking anything

When work piles up

YOU SEE There are 400 reports. Only 60 get opened.

1	Tag reports nobody opened in 13 months.	1.01
2	Name an owner for each report kept.	2.01
3	Trim the pages nobody reads.	6.02

S.10 Turn repeat requests into self-service

When work piles up

YOU SEE Your team has become everyone's help desk.

1	Tally a month of requests by type.	8.03
2	Bring every request through one door.	2.03
3	Turn the top three into simple forms.	6.05

S.11 Spread the load

When work piles up

YOU SEE Two people carry every urgent call-out.

1	Count call-outs against their hours.	4.01
2	Put urgent call-outs on a weekly duty rota.	4.08
3	Train more people in three passes.	2.06 · 2.07

S.12 Fix it at the source

When work piles up

YOU SEE The same question arrives fifty times a week.

1	Log and rank the questions.	6.06
2	Ask why users get stuck.	5.02
3	Change the screen so it answers itself.	6.05

S.13 Fix how changes go live

When things go wrong

YOU SEE A Friday change broke. Nobody could undo it.

1	Name one owner for each change.	2.01
2	Write the way back and test it.	1.03
3	Go live for a small group first.	8.04 · 5.06

S.14 Make failures loud

When things go wrong

YOU SEE A night run failed. Nobody noticed until morning.

1	Make each run send a done message.	5.07
2	Send a first report within 30 minutes.	5.03
3	Fix the cause after the re-run.	5.02

S.15 Lead it, then fix the process

When things go wrong

YOU SEE Figures were counted twice and went out wrong.

1	Name one person in charge.	5.04
2	Tell users before they find it.	5.03
3	Make re-runs safe, then check the first output.	5.02 · 6.04

S.16 Plan the fallback in advance

When things go wrong

YOU SEE A key system fails on report day.

1	Write a backup plan for each key system.	2.05
2	Name one person in charge on the day.	5.04
3	Practise the fallback each quarter.	5.05 · 1.03

S.17 Make it safe to change

When things go wrong

YOU SEE One old spreadsheet runs everything. Nobody dares touch it.

1	Watch what it actually does.	7.05
2	Hand the knowledge to a second person.	2.06
3	Write the rebuild steps down.	1.03

S.18 Find the cost and cut it

When things go wrong

YOU SEE A running cost doubled. Nobody knows why.

1	Count the spend per task and rank it.	8.02 · 8.03
2	Watch the top five tasks run.	7.05
3	Cut what nobody reads.	6.02

S.19 Settle it once

Working with other teams

YOU SEE Finance and sales report different revenue.

1	Ask the person over both heads to name the owner.	2.01
2	Talk to each side before the meeting.	3.05
3	Write the decision down.	3.04

S.20 Make changes arrive with warning

Working with other teams

YOU SEE Another team changed a report you rely on.

1	Map the hand-off on one page.	2.04
2	Ask for five days' notice. If refused, take it to your boss.	2.03
3	Check what arrives and send errors back.	6.07

S.21 Find out and keep it current

Working with other teams

YOU SEE An audit asks who can see customer data.

1	List everyone who can reach the data.	8.02
2	Name an owner for each data set.	2.01
3	Remove access nobody needs.	2.02

S.22 Stop it happening twice

Working with other teams

YOU SEE Your team's change broke another team's work.

1	Send each affected team a first report.	5.03
2	List every team that uses the tool.	7.05
3	Talk to each team before the next change.	3.05

S.23 Give each one an owner and a clean hand-off

Working with other teams

YOU SEE Customer requests bounce between two teams.

1	Map the request path across both teams.	2.04
2	Agree what a hand-off contains.	6.02
3	Keep one owner with the customer.	2.01

S.24 Hear it first next time

Working with other teams

YOU SEE An angry customer went straight to your boss.

1	Brief your boss and call the customer.	5.03
2	Put key accounts on the board.	7.01
3	Agree what must reach you that day.	7.02

T Toolkit

Six sheets to copy. Then what to run and how often, and the Japanese terms.

TEMPLATES

T.01 Ownership page 47
One page per team.

T.04 Handover sheet 47
One sheet per task or report run.

T.07 5W1H request check 48
Who, what, when, where, why, how.

T.08 A3 problem report 48
Toyota's one-page report for a problem too big for a kaizen card.

T.09 Team board 49
One board per team, at the place where the stand-up happens.

T.11 Measure sheet 49
Baseline, Pareto tally (biggest causes first) and cost of quality for one problem, kept on the board until the 90-day check.

PLAN AND REFERENCE

What to run, and how often 50

Japanese terms 51

T.01 TEMPLATE

Ownership page.

One page per team. Review it when a task, report or person is added.

TASK	OWNER	CHECKER	DECIDER	LEVEL
Overnight orders report run	Priya	none	Priya	Decide alone
Format changes, shared reports	Lee	Priya	You	Ask first
System access by role	Tom	Monthly audit	You	Ask first
Monthly report to the board	Priya	Sam	Priya	Decide, tell after

ESCALATE TO YOU

Failures customers notice, spend over budget, access to personal data.

ESCALATE BY

Within 30 minutes if customers notice. Same day for the rest.

TIPS

01
Write it with the person, from their last two weeks of real requests.

02
Every shared task has exactly one owner.

T.04 TEMPLATE

Handover sheet.

One sheet per task or report run. Context here, method in the how-to guide, practice in the three passes.

What it is	Overnight orders run, 14 reports
Who it serves	Finance dashboards, by 07:00
Folder	Team folder / Orders
Logins	Named logins by role, shared login in the password manager
How-to guide	G-07 Re-run a failed report
Open now	Two requests, ORD-212 and ORD-219
Quirks	Supplier file can arrive after 06:00

THREE PASSES

PASS	DATE	OK
1 Watch	2026-10-05	Yes
2 Do, watched	2026-10-08	Yes
3 Do alone	2026-10-15	

Sign off only after pass 3.

TIPS

01
Start on the first day of notice.

02
No passwords here. Point to the password manager.

T.07 TEMPLATE

5W1H request check.

Who, what, when, where, why, how. Any request is complete when all six lines are filled.

LINE	EXAMPLE	YOUR REQUEST
Who	Ana needs it. Priya decides. Copy the manager.	
What	A daily list of failed payments for customer service	
When	First file by Thursday 15:00. Daily from Monday.	
Where	Restricted view in the customer service system, by role	
Why	Customer service calls before the second payment attempt fails	
How	No card numbers. Updated after the 02:00 overnight run.	

TIPS

01
Use it for every request you send or receive.

02
A line is empty? Ask before you start.

03
The why line is the one most often missing. Ask for it.

T.08 TEMPLATE

A3 problem report.

Toyota's one-page report for a problem too big for a kaizen card. Seven boxes, in order. Keep it to one page in the team folder.

PROBLEM The monthly report goes out late every month OWNER Priya DATE 2026-10-12

1 Background	The Monday report goes out on Thursday. Managers wait three days for figures.
2 Current state	The report takes 3 days. Waits: finance figures 1.5 days, sign-off 1 day.
3 Goal	Report out on Monday, by 12:00.
4 Root cause	Finance closes our accounts last in its queue. No one owns sign-off.
5 Fix	Finance closes our accounts first, in week 1. Your boss asks the finance lead. The reporting lead signs off by 10:00 Monday.
6 Check	Next report: start and finish times, waits per step.
7 Follow-up	Update guide G-04. Review after two reports.
Result	

TIPS

01
One sheet. If it does not fit, split the problem.

02
Write the current state from what you saw yourself.

03
The person closest to the problem writes it. The manager reviews it.

T.09 TEMPLATE

Team board.

One board per team, at the place where the stand-up happens. Four zones, read in five seconds.

MEASURES

MEASURE	TARGET	NOW	STATUS
Requests done on time	95%	91%	Red
Right first time	95%	97%	Green
Oldest open request	5 days	9 days	Red

PROBLEMS AND ESCALATIONS

PROBLEM	OWNER	RAISED TO	DUE
Supplier file late	Priya	Leads	13 Oct

WORK IN PROGRESS (MAX 3 EACH IN DOING)

TO DO	DOING	DONE
Q4 capacity plan	Order system, Sam · 4 days	Oct price change
Access review	Orders fix, Priya · 2 days	Re-run how-to guide
Next year's plan	Warnings, Lee · 9 days	

KAIZEN IN PROGRESS (MAX 3)

Required date field	Sam	trial to 26 Oct
Totals check	Priya	30-day check

TIPS

01
Three measures. More and nobody reads them.

02
The stand-up happens at the board, every day.

03
Red means a conversation. If red brings blame, the board will stay green.

T.11 TEMPLATE

Measure sheet.

Baseline, Pareto tally (biggest causes first) and cost of quality for one problem, kept on the board until the 90-day check.

Problem	Orders sent back after sign-off
Counted as	Orders sent back, of all sent, per fortnight
Before	14 of 80 (18%)
Change	Checklist added to the second check
After	3 of 78 (4%)
Rechecks	30 days: 4%. 90 days:

PARETO TALLY, BIGGEST CAUSES FIRST, TWO WEEKS

Missing delivery detail	8
Wrong price	3
Unclear request	2
Other	1

COST OF QUALITY, TWO WEEKS

Fixing	11 h
Chasing	7 h
Redoing	5 h

TIPS

01
Count two weeks before any change.

02
Count the same way after.

Section 3 · Toolkit

What to run, and how often

Start one routine a week. Keep the ones that save time, and drop the rest on purpose.

CALENDAR

THE FIRST FOUR WEEKS

Week 1	Go and see. Put up the team board.	7.05 · 7.01 · T.09
Week 2	Start the stand-up and the four-line update. Write the ownership page.	3.06 · 3.02 · 2.01 · T.01
Week 3	Write your own routines. Agree decision levels.	7.03 · 2.02
Week 4	Take a baseline. Book the weekly kaizen hour.	8.02 · 8.09 · T.11

THEN, EVERY DAY, WEEK, MONTH AND QUARTER

WHEN	WHAT	WHO	TIME	ROUTINE · PAGE
Daily	Board check	You	5 min	7.01 32
	Stand-up, ten minutes	Team	10 min	3.06 16
	Leads' huddle	Leads	10 min	7.02 33
	Kamishibai card, spot check	You	5 min	8.05 37
	Four-line update	Everyone	2 min, 16:30	3.02 15
	Overnight jobs: done messages seen	You	2 min	5.07 27
Weekly	Gemba walk, go and see	You	30 min	7.05 34
	Kaizen hour	Team	60 min	8.09 38
	PDCA check-in (plan, do, check, act), first 15 min of the kaizen hour	Team	in the hour	8.01 36
	Friday reset	Everyone	10 min	1.01 05
	Key dates, the next 90 days	You	10 min	4.10 23
	Duty rota handover	Team	5 min	4.08 22
Monthly	Quality tally and top cause	You	30 min	6.01 29
	Failure demand review	You and owners	30 min	6.06 30
	How-to guide audit	Owners	30 min	1.03 06
	Leader standard work misses	You	10 min	7.03 33
	Hoshin review, yearly goals	You and your boss	30 min	7.04 33
	Skills matrix update	You and the team	15 min	2.07 11
	Unplanned work log against the reserve	You	15 min	4.05 21
	Workaround list review	Owners	15 min	5.08 27
Quarterly	Demand and capacity recount	You	1 h	4.01 20
	Cost of quality recount	Team	1 h	6.01 29
	Yokoten swap, sharing fixes	Leads	30 min	8.06 37
	Supplier review	Owners	1 h	6.07 31
	Backup login test	Owners	30 min	2.09 11
	Drill: rehearse one failure	Team	30 min	5.05 26
	Meeting reset	You	30 min	3.11 18
	Stop doing: pause one report	You and the team	15 min	8.12 39

Section 3 · Toolkit

Japanese terms

The words you will hear, grouped by method. Most come from the Toyota Production System and everyday Japanese working practice.

REFERENCE

TERM	JAPANESE	WHAT IT MEANS AT WORK	PAGE
Seeing and updates			
Genchi genbutsu	現地現物	Go and see the real place and the real thing before you decide.	34
Hō-ren-sō	報連相	Report, inform, consult. The three ways news should move.	14
Hōkoku	報告	Report the result of work you were given.	15
Renraku	連絡	Inform others of facts they need.	14
Sōdan	相談	Consult before you decide or get stuck.	15
Ketsuron kara	結論から	Conclusion first, then the detail.	15
5S			
Seiri	整理	Sort. Remove what you do not need.	05
Seiton	整頓	Set in order. A place for everything.	05
Seisō	清掃	Shine. Clean and check as you go.	05
Seiketsu	清潔	Standardise. Same way for everyone.	05
Shitsuke	躾	Sustain. Keep the habit going.	05
Kaizen and waste			
Kaizen	改善	Improvement. In practice, small steps made continuously.	06, 36
Muda	無駄	Waste. Effort that adds no value.	04, 29
Mura	ムラ	Unevenness. Peaks and troughs in work.	21
Muri	無理	Overburden. More than a person can carry.	20
Standard work and quality			
Hikitsugi	引き継ぎ	Handover of work to the next person.	10
Hoshitori-hyō	星取表	Star chart. A grid of who can do each task alone, with help, or is learning.	11
Hyōjun sagyō	標準作業	Standard work. The current best way, with its sequence and timing.	06
Jidoka	自働化	Build in checks so work stops when something is wrong, then fix the cause.	25
Poka-yoke	ポカヨケ	Mistake-proofing. The error cannot happen, or is caught the moment it does.	30
Naze naze	なぜなぜ	Asking why, usually five times, to reach the cause.	25

Hours

Teiji	定時	The scheduled end of the working day.	20
Zangyō	残業	Overtime. A signal that the plan or process is wrong.	20
Tsukiai zangyō	付き合い残業	Staying late to keep others company.	20
Heijunka	平準化	Levelling. Spreading work so there are no peaks.	21
Yutori	ゆとり	Room to spare. An everyday word, with no special Toyota meaning. Here, time held back for work nobody planned.	21
Tōban	当番	Duty rota. Whose turn it is to take the interruptions this week.	22

When things go wrong

Andon	アンドン	A signal anyone can raise to stop work and get help.	25
Saihatsu bōshi	再発防止	Preventing a problem from happening again.	25
Shohō	初報	The first, short report that something has gone wrong.	25
Kunren	訓練	Training by doing. Here, a scheduled rehearsal of a failure.	26

Meetings

Nemawashi	根回し	Talking to each person a decision affects, before the meeting.	16
Chōrei	朝礼	The short morning gathering. Close in purpose to the daily stand-up.	16
Gijiroku	議事録	Minutes: decisions, owners and dates.	16

Running the team

Mieruka	見える化	Making work and problems visible to everyone.	32
Hoshin kanri	方針管理	Turning a few yearly goals into each team's work.	33
Catchball	キャッチボール	Passing a goal down and the plan back up until both agree.	33
Gemba	現場	The real place where the work happens.	34
Kata	型	A practised routine. Coaching kata is Mike Rother's account of Toyota practice.	34

Improving and quality at the source

Yokoten	横展開	From yokotenkai: spreading a proven fix sideways to other teams.	37
Kamishibai	紙芝居	Picture-card theatre. In lean, quick daily spot checks of a standard, one card at a time.	37
Hansei	反省	Honest reflection after the work.	38
Jikōtei kanketsu	自工程完結	Each step finishes its own quality.	29
Hatsumono kensa	初物検査	Checking the first item of a batch before doing the rest.	30
Kajō kakō	過剰加工	Over-processing. More polish than anyone needs.	29
A3	A3	Toyota's one-page problem report, named after the paper size.	25, 37

改善

Pick one standard. Make it visible. Use it every day. Improve it in small steps.

WHERE TO START

03 **You have five minutes**
Read the book on one page, then pick one thing to try on Monday.

02 **Something keeps going wrong**
Find the part that matches your week and read its patterns.

50 **You are setting up a team**
Start one routine a week, and copy the templates.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Sanjay Chandra

Sanjay wrote this book as a personal project. It is free. Share it with anyone setting up how their team works.

www.ssanjaychandra.com · github.com/ssanjaychandra123 · linkedin.com/in/ssanjaychandra

Version 1.0 · October 2026

CC BY 4.0 · Free to share and adapt, with credit